call home, to revel in the wonders we discover, and to hand off our knowledge to those who follow.

For a species that, by cosmic time scales, has only just learned to walk upright, the challenges are staggering. Yet, over the last three hundred years, as we've progressed from classical to relativistic and then to quantum reality, and have now moved on to explorations of unified reality, our minds and instruments have swept across the grand expanse of space and time, bringing us closer than ever to a world that has proved a deft master of disguise. And as we've continued to slowly unmask the cosmos, we've gained the intimacy that comes only from closing in on the clarity of truth. The explorations have far to go, but to many it feels as though our species is finally reaching childhood's end.

To be sure, our coming of age here on the outskirts of the Milky Way[6] has been a long time in the making. In one way or another, we've been exploring our world and contemplating the cosmos for thousands of years. But for most of that time we made only brief forays into the unknown, each time returning home somewhat wiser but largely unchanged. It took the brashness of a Newton to plant the flag of modern scientific inquiry and never turn back. We've been heading higher ever since. And all our travels began with a simple question.

What is space?